GLASSHOUSE

KRISHNA CONSCIOUSNESS



Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

Delhi chief minister Arvind Kejriwal has often projected himself as a Hanuman *bhakt*. However, on a recent visit to poll-bound Gujarat, the Aam Aadmi Party convenor invoked Lord Krishna, Gujarat being the state where the deity's kingdom, Dwarka, lay, and which is one of the *char dhams* of the Hindu pilgrimage circuit today. Kejriwal said he had a natural right to take on the evil king Kansa—read BJP—being born on the day Janmashtami was celebrated that year. A miffed BJP googled the date—August 16, 1968—and claimed Janmashtami that year fell a day before Kejriwal's DoB. Fact-checkers say both sides are correct—the celestial positions for Janmashtami straddled August 15-16 in 1968. Scores even for now.

BLACK MAGIC CM



ANI

As K. Chandrasekhar Rao (KCR) revealed his national ambition by renaming his Telangana Rashtra Samithi the Bharat Rashtra Samithi, BJP leader and Union finance minister Nirmala Sitharaman claimed that the Telangana chief minister had fallen prey to tantric advice. The state BJP alleged that he had been "undertaking occult practices using a black cat at his farmhouse", where he spends at least two days a week. KCR has been silent, but his nephew, the state's finance and health minister T. Harish Rao, has said that unlike the BJP, which started a course in Bhoot Vidya at BHU, the TRS relies on Loktantra vidya, not tantra.

Micro Mismanagement

The Congress is attempting to get its act together in Uttar Pradesh. Except that it has ended up creating more confusion. The party has appointed one state president and six working ones for the six zones it has divided the state into. These zones, in turn, each have an in-charge, who reports directly to general secretary Priyanka Gandhi. Party functionaries now do not know which of the 13 bosses to report to—the president, the working presidents or the zonal in-charges. Every boss has his own coterie. While the exercise intended to change the fortunes of the party, it seems to have caused further divide among the ranks. As a senior state functionary said, "We are doing too many experiments but gaining nothing." Too much of a good thing is not all good, it seems.

POST SCRIPT

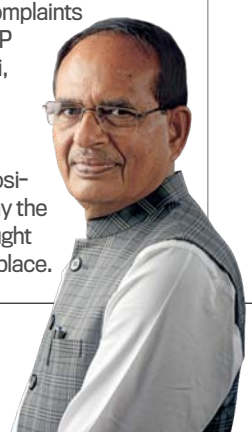




It's rare for a party president, especially in a disciplined unit like the BJP, to criticise bureaucratic reshuffle, a chief ministerial prerogative. So, when Gujarat BJP president **C.R. Patil** recently said that IAS officer **Banchhanidhi Pani**, who was transferred from Surat, should have been made municipal commissioner of Ahmedabad instead of Vadodara, it created a stir. It came as an endorsement of Pani's public displeasure at his posting. But then Pani is no ordinary babu. When Vijay Rupani was CM, he was the Rajkot municipal commissioner and his wife's camaraderie with Rupani's wife Anjali was the talk of the town.

AN OFFICER BUT NO GENTLEMAN

When a police inspector was transferred out of Indore a few months ago, a powerful cabinet colleague close to the official told Madhya Pradesh chief minister **Shivraj Singh Chouhan** not to expect any cooperation if the inspector was not brought back. Chouhan capitulated, but then suspended the official on October 8, reportedly on complaints by Indore BJP MP Shankar Lalwani, who accused the inspector of indulging in extortion. The Opposition is asking why the officer was brought back in the first place.



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

Kaushik Deka with ***Kiran D. Tare. Jumana Shah, Rahul Noronha, Amarnath K. Menon and Prashant Srivastava***